

after the overthrow of the old Babylonian Empire, as is proved by the testimony of Quintus Curtius (v. 1). And if the custom was known to a Roman writer who probably lived under Vespasian, why should it not have been known to a Palestinian writer who lived centuries earlier?

Another Babylonian practice mentioned in Daniel is the punishment of burning alive (chap. iii.). But since, in Jer. xxix. 22, Nebuchadnezzar is described as *roasting* offenders *in the fire*, and since this very chapter is elsewhere quoted by the author of Daniel (chap. ix. 2; cf. Jer. xxix. 10), there can be no difficulty in explaining whence his knowledge was derived.

Thus it will be seen that one proof after another breaks down, and it would be a waste of time to discuss arguments still more fanciful, of which a large and varied collection has been made by Mr Fuller in the *Speaker's Commentary*.

The result of this chapter has hitherto been mainly negative. We have seen that there is no external testimony to the Book of Daniel before the middle of the 2nd century before Christ, and that the narrative of Daniel is seriously at variance with the history of the period in which Daniel is represented as living. But it is fortunately possible for us to advance from negative to positive conclusions. It can be shewn that external evidence and internal evidence both point in the same direction, or in other words that the first half of the 2nd century before Christ—after which period the external testimony begins—is the only period which will explain the contents of the book.

The Book of Daniel is divided into two parts; the first consists of a series of narratives, the second of a series of prophetic visions. In the narratives Daniel is always mentioned in the third person, whereas in the visions he is himself the speaker. The narratives are evidently intended to be consecutive, in point of time, but they are very loosely connected with each other. Their most marked feature is the didactic purpose which appears throughout. In every one of these stories we see the righteous rewarded or the wicked signally punished, as the case may be. On the one hand Daniel and